EXAM OVERVIEW

Cambridge English Qualification A2 Key for Schools Exam, otherwise known as **Cambridge Key for Schools**, is an examination set at **A2 level** of the Common European Framework of Reference for Languages (CEFR). It is made up of **three papers**, each testing a different area of ability in English: Reading and Writing, Listening, and Speaking.

Reading and Writing	1 hour	50% of the marks
Listening	35 minutes (approximately)	25% of the marks
Speaking	8–10 minutes for each pair of students (approximately)	25% of the marks

All the examination questions are task-based. Rubrics (instructions) are important and candidates should read them carefully. They set the context and give important information about the tasks. There are separate answer sheets for recording answers for the Reading and Writing paper and the Listening paper.

Paper	Format	Task focus
Reading and Writing Seven Parts 32 questions	**Part 1: three-option multiple choice.** Reading six short texts and choosing the correct answer.	**Part 1:** reading short texts for the main idea, detail, and writer's purpose.
	Part 2: matching. Reading three short texts or paragraphs on the same topic and matching the correct text or paragraph to the question.	**Part 2:** reading for detailed understanding.
	Part 3: three-option multiple choice. Five multiple-choice questions.	**Part 3:** reading for main idea(s), detail, opinion, attitude and writer's purpose.
	Part 4: three-option multiple-choice cloze. Reading a text with six gaps and selecting the correct word to complete each gap.	**Part 4:** reading and identifying appropriate words.
	Part 5: open cloze. Short text with six gaps. Completing the text with one word in each gap.	**Part 5:** reading and writing appropriate words to fill in the gaps.
	Part 6: guided writing; writing a short message. Reading an email or reading about a situation and writing an email.	**Part 6:** Writing an email to a friend including three pieces of information. 25 words or more
	Part 7: guided writing; writing a short narrative. Three pictures which show a story.	**Part 7:** Writing the short story shown in the three pictures. 35 words or more
Listening Five Parts 25 questions	**Part 1:** three-option multiple choice. Listening to five short dialogues and choosing the correct picture for each answer.	**Part 1:** listening to identify key information.
	Part 2: gap fill. Listening to a longer monologue and writing the missing word, number, date or time in five gaps.	**Part 2:** listening and writing down information.
	Part 3: three-option multiple choice. Listening to a longer dialogue and choosing the correct answer to five questions.	**Part 3:** listening to identify key information, feelings and opinions.
	Part 4: three-option multiple choice. Listening to five short dialogues or monologues and choosing the correct answer for each text-based question.	**Part 4:** listening for gist, main idea or topic.
	Part 5: matching. Listening to a longer dialogue and matching five questions with seven options. An example is given.	**Part 5:** listening to identify specific information.
Speaking Two Parts	**Part 1:** interview: examiner-led conversation. 3-4 minutes	**Part 1:** giving personal information.
	Part 2: collaborative task: two-way conversation with visual prompt. Examiner asks two more questions to broaden the topic. 5-6 minutes	**Part 2:** asking and answering simple questions, expressing likes and dislikes and giving reasons.

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A2 KEY for Schools Top 20 Questions

1 What is the format of the A2 KEY for Schools exam, and are all the papers taken on the same day?

There are three papers:

➤ Reading and Writing (1 hour)
Listening (about 30 minutes) Speaking (9–10 minutes)
Papers 1 and 2 are always taken on the same day. The Speaking test may be taken on the same day or on a different day.

2 How is the A2 KEY for Schools exam different from the A2 KEY exam?

➤ KET for Schools follows the same format as KET. The difference is that the content and topics in KET for Schools are more suitable for the interests and experiences of younger people.

3 What level is the A2 KEY for Schools exam?

➤ The KEY for Schools exam is aligned to the Council of Europe Common European Framework for Reference (CEFR) and is level A2 in the CEFR.

4 Is the A2 KEY for schools exam suitable for teenagers from any culture?

➤ Yes. All tasks are written to avoid any cultural bias.

5 What are the grade ranges for the A2 KEY for Schools exam?

➤ There are four grades with fixed values: Pass with merit = 85–100%
Pass = 70–84%
A1 = 45–69%
Fail = 44% and below

6 Do I have to pass each paper in order to pass the exam?

➤ No. Each paper doesn't have a pass or fail mark. The final mark a candidate gets in KET for Schools is an average mark obtained by adding the marks for all three papers together.

7 What mark do I need to get to pass the exam overall?

➤ To achieve a pass in the A2 KEY for Schools exam a candidate must receive a minimum of 70% as an overall average.

8 When can I use pens or pencils in the exam?

➤ In the A2 KEY for Schools exam, a candidate must use pencil in all papers.

9 If I write entirely in capital letters, does this affect my score?

➤ No. Candidates are not penalised for writing in capitalsin the exam.

10 Am I allowed to use a dictionary?

➤ No.

11 Is correct spelling important in Paper 1 (Reading and Writing)?

➤ It is important only in Parts 5, 6 and 7.

12 Is correct spelling important in Paper 2 (Listening)?

➤ It is important only in Part 2.

13 In Paper 1 (Reading and Writing) will extra time be given for me to transfer my answers to the answer sheet?

➤ No. You must transfer them in the 1 hour you are given to complete the exam in.

14 In Paper 2 (Listening) will extra time be given for me to transfer my answers to the answer sheet?

➤ Yes. You will be given some time at the end of the test for this.

15 How many times will I hear each recording in Paper 2 (Listening)?

➤ You will hear each recording twice.

16 Can I ask any questions if I don't understand something in Papers 1 (Reading and Writing) and 2 (Listening)?

➤ The only questions you can ask are those that relate to the rules of the exam. For example, the time you have, where to write your name or your answers, completing the answer sheet, whether or not you can use a pen, etc. You cannot ask for any help with the test items themselves.

17 Can I ask any questions if I don't understand something in Paper 3 (Speaking)?

➤ Yes. You can ask the examiner to repeat a question in Part 1 and to repeat the instructions in Part 2. If you still don't understand, tell the examiner you don't understand. You can ask your partner to repeat or clarify when they are asking you questions or answering your questions in Part 2.

18 In Paper 3 (Speaking), do I have to go in with another student? Can I choose my partner?

➤ You cannot be examined alone. You will usually be examined with one other candidate, but if you are one of the last candidates to be examined and there is an odd number of candidates on the day, you may be examined in a group of three. In some smaller centres you may be able to choose your partner, but in bigger centres this may not be possible.

19 In Paper 3 (Speaking), is it a good idea for me to prepare what I am going to say in Part 1?

➤ It's a good idea to practise saying your name, spelling your surname and talking about yourself (your family, school, school subjects, hobbies, etc.). It is important that you answer the examiner's questions and that you do so naturally, so listen carefully and think about the questions you have been asked. If you give a prepared speech you may not answer the examiner's question. You will lose marks if your answers are irrelevant.

20 In Paper 3 (Speaking), what if I can't understand my partner in Part 2 or if he/she can't understand me?

➤ If there is a communication breakdown between you and your partner in Part 2, try to solve the problem between you. For example, ask your partner for clarification or to repeat a question or an answer, or help your partner if necessary. You will be given credit for helping your partner if he/she is having difficulty.

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